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Art and Moral Knowledge[1]

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Disputes about the moral content of art have been prominent in the news in recent years—Cincinnati *vs.* Mapplethorpe, Jesse Helms *vs.* Andres Serrano and the NEA, Islamic mullahs *vs.* Salman Rushdie, the cops vs. Ice-T. There is nothing strikingly new in these debates. Artists in other eras were threatened with penalties as severe as death for their "sacrilegious" art: Aeschylus for exposing the Eleusinian mysteries in his tragedies, Michelangelo for exposing the genitalia in his *Risen Christ.*[2] But just what is the power of art to challenge moral beliefs? The modern cases have generated more heat than light. Noted art critic Lucy Lippard comments that moral issues "are still generally avoided in the high-art 'discourse,' where the word 'moral' is usually considered either laughable, rhetorical and/or the property of the Right."[3]

Yet if we delve into the interpretive literature on these troubling artists, we *can* find specific accounts of the moral messages of their works. Lippard says, "Serrano has developed a complex iconography that simultaneously exorcises the artist's experiences of Catholicism, criticizes the commercialization of sacred imagery and pays idiosyncratic homage to ideas that Christ originally stood for."[4] Arthur Danto finds related Catholic concerns with the flesh-become-spirit in Robert Mapplethorpe's notorious image, *Jim and Tom, Sausalito,* a triptych that depicts one man urinating into another's mouth. Danto interprets this as the presentation through religiously derived iconography of a spiritual sexual interaction: "The photograph accepts the dark truth

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of their deflected passion, and celebrates it."[5] Jerrold Levinson reads Ice-T's rap song "High Rollers" as an ironically self-referential denunciation of the pusher's superficial commitment to commercial values.[6] And Wendy Steiner says about the Jahilia section of Rushdie's *Satanic Verses* that "[t]here could hardly be a more direct attack on a fundamentalist construal of the holy word."[7]

Does art in such cases present moral claims, and can it provide moral knowledge? In what sense? Do photographs, novels, or songs present truths, facts, theses, and arguments? Or do they stimulate cognitive activity in some other way? What sort of activity, and how is it relevant to morality? And how in general is the moral content of works of art related to their artistic value? In this essay I shall explore some answers to these questions.

ART AND COGNITION

Some people do not think artworks make cognitive contributions. In his recent article, "On the Cognitive Triviality of Art," Jerome Stolnitz flatly denies that art contributes to knowledge.[8] He argues that if art is to add to knowledge, then it must provide us with truths; but his exploration of likely truths gleaned from great novelists like George Eliot results in findings that are "distressingly impoverished." So he concludes that what truths there are to be derived from art are "distinctly banal" and "could probably have been arrived at otherwise."[9] Along with such a narrow, discursive notion of knowledge, the noncognitivist about art will probably also adopt a narrow conception of learning as acquiring facts, testing or confirming hypotheses, and/or being persuaded by arguments. Such people would say that since art cannot teach us facts or offer arguments, we cannot learn from it.

If art is cognitively trivial, it is hard to see why artworks like those I mentioned at the start have been held to be so disturbing in recent controversies. The alternative view, and the one I favor, is that art is not cognitively trivial: it may add to and advance our knowledge. An aesthetician might defend this view while retaining a narrow notion of knowledge as the presentation of theses and arguments. For example, Levinson, in his article "Messages in Art," argues that artists make "utterances" in a communicative network; some of these may be proposition-like in nature. Thus, Levinson interprets a controversial feminist college art project entitled "Rape Piece" as making the utterance that "all college men are potential rapists."[10] I am not sure that Levinson himself adopts a narrow account of knowledge in art; but one could do so in principle. However, I shall not pursue this sort of narrow cognitivism about art here.

In this paper I shall consider two promising cognitivist approaches to art: "Aristotelianism" and "pragmatism." Both employ a broadened, nondis-

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cursive conception of knowledge—not just as theses and propositions, but as understanding, insight, empathy, imagination, the creation and discovery of new perceptual schemas, new worlds, or new relationships among things. For the pragmatist, knowledge in general is broadly conceived: it involves acquiring beliefs or explanations that meet the needs of inquirers in certain circumstances. In his seminal essay, "How to Make Our Ideas Clear," Peirce actually uses a musical metaphor to describe the epistemic notion of belief: "And what, then, is belief? Belief is the demi-cadence which closes a musical phrase in the symphony of our intellectual life."[11] Belief for Peirce is a rule for action, something that appeases the irritation of doubt; he comments that "the whole function of thought is to produce habits of action."[12]

The Aristotelian position is more complex, because Aristotle distinguished moral knowledge from scientific knowledge. He held a somewhat narrow conception of theoretical knowledge, but a broader view of moral knowledge.[13] The former involves providing explanations drawn from first principles and proper scientific demonstrations; the latter involves having the right perceptions, desires, feelings, and habits of actions. Not surprisingly, both Aristotelians and pragmatists employ a broad notion of moral *learning:* they do not consider it solely to involve testing hypotheses, confirming truths, or acquiring theses, propositions, and arguments. They are open to saying that we can learn from artworks in some broader sense. I shall focus below on two exponents of these positions, Martha Nussbaum and Hilary Putnam, who defend the importance of moral learning from art. But first I must prepare some ground.

FORMALIST AUTONOMY THEORIES OF ARTISTIC AND MORAL VALUE

To set the stage, it will be useful to sketch some alternative positions on the relation between moral content and artistic value in artworks.[14] Some thinkers maintain that the artistic value of an artwork is separate and distinct from any value attached to its contents. Moral content and aesthetic merit are autonomous; there are distinctive aesthetic reasons for valuing art that are conceptually independent from the content of artworks—and so in particular from their moral content.[15] Of course, a beautiful work may possess a certain content, but attending to this is separate from attending to its aesthetic merits.

Often, autonomy theorists maintain that artistic value resides in *formal* features of the work of art. Formalism in aesthetics is usually traced back to Kant;[16] it had its fullest flowering in the work of art critics Roger Fry and Clement Greenberg.[17] Extreme formalists, in separating the value of a work's

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artistic features from its moral content, often regard that content as somehow external to the work's value as art. As such, content is linked to other supposedly "external" facts about the work's creator and the act of creation. For example, in his essay, "The Baby or the Botticelli," novelist and philosopher William Gass writes:

> The position I am trying to defend is not that literature has no relation to morality, or that reading and writing, or composing, or painting, aren't also moral, or possibly immoral, acts. But they are also economic acts as well. . . . The artistic value of a book, however, is different from its economic value. . . . Artistic quality depends upon a work's internal, formal, organic character, upon its inner system of relations, upon its structure and its style, and not upon the morality it is presumed to recommend, or upon the benevolence of its author, or its emblematic character, when it is seen as especially representative of some situation or society.[18]

Notice how Gass separates artistic quality—a matter of "internal" formal features—from moral content, which he suggests is "external" and linked to extraneous facts about the morality of the artist. *Writing* a book, symphony, or poem could be immoral, but the work's "artistic quality" falls under a separate evaluational category.

In his essay, Gass defends a strong autonomy thesis concerning aesthetic and moral value. Neither can trump the other or be reduced to the other; one kind of value does not suffice to confer the other. Though Gass refuses to allow that the moral content "in" (or as he would put it "recommended by") a work can be part of its artistic quality, he recognizes that these values are not completely independent, since realization of one kind of value may either causally thwart or promote the realization of the other kind. That is, an autonomy theorist may acknowledge indirect ways in which moral content interacts and perhaps collides with aesthetic value. Gass's position is not utterly implausible. Critics often fault Leni Riefenstahl for making the film *Triumph of the Will* as Nazi propaganda, while at the same time regarding the film as an excellent and influential piece of work, admiring such "artistic qualities" as its use of symbols, narrative, spectacle, editing, point of view, rhetoric, and so on. It may be hard to decide which kind of value "wins out" in the ultimate assessment of this work.

A more recent example may be found in critic Hilton Kramer's essay on Mapplethorpe, "Is Art above the Laws of Decency?" Kramer too finds it possible to separate the artistic value of Mapplethorpe's work from its moral content.[19] He concedes that ("alas") the photographs are art, but then argues that "not all forms of art are socially benign in either their intentions or their effects . . . certain forms of high culture are capable of having something other than a socially desirable impact on the sensibilities of young and old

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alike."[20] Kramer fears that excellence of quality in this case only makes the perverseness of the bad content more troubling.[21] Clearly two separate scales of evaluation are at work here.

Some formalists focus on the artistic value of a work to the point that they seem to ignore content altogether. Goodness of form almost seems to put an artwork "off the scales" of morality, so to speak. We can find examples of such extreme formalism in testimony given by expert witnesses at the Cincinnati obscenity trial focusing on Mapplethorpe's "The Perfect Moment" exhibition. Expert witness Janet Kardon pointed out the "almost classical" composition of the artist's self-portrait with bullwhip protruding from his anus and the "opposing diagonals" in the urination photo.[22] Formalist defenders seemed to discount, ignore, or even deny the importance of the content of Mapplethorpe's images. Arthur Danto says of these expert witnesses that "their vision of the work virtually erased the content" and comments that "the formalism of the experts did a great disservice, even if it got the museum and its director off the hook."[23]

An odd defender of this extreme formalism is Clive Bell, who went so far as to claim that good art (by which he meant art with significant form) has a moral value all its own: "Art is above morals, or, rather, all art is moral because . . . works of art are immediate means to good. Once we have judged a thing a work of art, we have judged it ethically of the first importance and put it beyond the reach of the moralist."[24] On this view, a formally good artwork excuses all problematic moral features—just as we might, say, make allowances for an evil person if we were enchanted by his or her physical beauty. Perhaps this is the view of people who say that the Egyptian pyramids or Jefferson's Monticello are wonderful aesthetic products we can now enjoy as such without guilt over the exploitation and slave labor that produced and sustained them, however regrettable that may have been.

I reject the kind of autonomy theories sketched here because I consider it unacceptable to separate a work's aesthetic features from its moral content in the ways suggested by Gass, Kramer, or Bell. Gass's distinction between factors that are internal and external to the work is hard to maintain. It is notoriously controversial whether we ought to separate the meaning of an artist's work so sharply from facts about his or her life, since knowledge of those facts may affect our construal of features seen in the work. It seems psychologically problematic and self-deceptive to admire a film like *Triumph of the Will* without noticing its immoral content or without relating this film to other work of Riefenstahl's or considering her relation to the Nazis.[25] As a comparison, we would feel concern for a friend who loves a beautiful person without regard to his or her evil character.

The real problem lies in the formalist's denial that a work's moral content can be part of what Gass calls its internal, organic, or "artistic" quality.

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We need a theory of artistic value that recognizes that in *Triumph of the Will,* as in the Mapplethorpe images, content is conceptually linked to "internal" aesthetic features and values. I agree with Danto that surely Mapplethorpe intended to create works with strong erotic content and a certain point of view.[26] In making such a sharp separation, the formalist effectively denies artists the power to express ideas and content in their work. But this seem simply false to the facts. The expression of moral ideas has always been central in art—from Greek tragedies, architecture, and sculpture, to Christian cathedrals, icons, and Bach masses; from Persian miniatures to landscape gardens; from Manuel Bravo public murals to Brecht operettas; from Walker Evans photographs to films like *Schindler's List.*

In sum, the limitations of formalist autonomy theories of art are these: (1) They implausibly separate content in general from what contributes to aesthetic value; (2) In particular, they too sharply separate moral content from aesthetic features of works; and (3) They do not offer plausible accounts of the psychology of experiencing art, because they invoke a self-deceptive view about our ability to separate aesthetic from moral judgments about works of art. Formalist autonomy theories do not offer an acceptable account either of art's moral content or of how we may learn from artworks.

MORALISM

The *moralist* maintains that moral content is relevant—indeed even crucial—to a work's artistic functioning and value. If a work of art presents an immoral content, it is either bad art or not art at all.[27] There are two variants of moralism. The *reductive* moralist says that there are certain types of bad content that rule a candidate for art out altogether. The *strong* moralist says that the artistic disvalue of a work can be directly inferred from its presentation of unacceptable moral content. Many of the critics of Ice-T, Salman Rushdie, and Mapplethorpe were extreme moralists who held one of these two views. For the moralist, artistic value and moral value are not autonomous.[28]

Moralists hold that a work's artistic merit is, to at least some degree, a direct function of its moral value. Many moralists seem to hold the overly simple view that an artwork's moral value resides in a certain content that may be discerned without attention to its artistic features. For example, U.S. Senator Al D'Amato exhibited reductive moralism in denouncing Serrano's photograph *Piss Christ,* the image of a crucifix submerged in urine. D'Amato could not even conceive of regarding this image as art. He seemed to infer that the work's title was a direct indication of its (unacceptable) content, remarking in the U.S. Senate, "to be quite candid, I am somewhat reluctant to utter its title. This so-called piece of art is a deplorable, despicable display

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of vulgarity."[29] He went on to refer to the photograph as "this piece of trash," "garbage," and "filth," and he tore up a catalog containing the image on the floor of the Senate.

Strong moralism, in contrast to reductive moralism, allows that a work with disgusting or bad content may be art, but considers it bad art to the degree that its content is morally problematic. George Dickie defends this sort of approach in his book *Evaluating Art,* and he thinks that Hume also held something like it in his essay "On the Standard of Taste." Dickie comments,

> Hume does not give an argument in support of his view, and I expect that he did not think that any argument is required. It is obvious that many works of art have an integral moral point of view, and it was equally obvious to Hume that one cannot take a neutral stance toward a moral point of view. Anyone who has a moral point of view is bound to evaluate the moral point of view of any work that has one. Thus, anyone with a moral point of view will find the moral point of view of a work of art that has one to be either valuable or disvaluable.[30]

In his book Dickie lays out a moralist position that directly infers some degree of artistic value or disvalue of a work from the moral value or disvalue of what it represents. He also argues that artistic worth varies according to whether a work represents the moral value or disvalue of what it shows "approvingly or disapprovingly."[31] (So, for example, a didactic film like *Schindler's List* that shows the Nazis disapprovingly thereby gains in artistic merit.) Dickie explains, "The representation in works of art of anything valuable (in isolation from the other properties of the work) is always valuable."[32]

I criticized formalist autonomy views for too sharply separating moral value from aesthetic value. Such theories tend to overemphasize the unique value of aesthetic features of artworks (like form). Moralism does link artistic and moral values, but it goes to the other extreme by not providing enough recognition of the role of aesthetic features in establishing moral content. It errs by treating moral value as too distinct, independent, and preeminent. Dickie may allow that to identify and assess a work's moral value we might have to assess and identify its aesthetic or artistic value. But still, the moral value of the thing actually represented in the work is always aesthetically relevant. He says, "The value of experiencing referent-centered cognitive value flows from *the value of the thing referred to.*"[33] Dickie's theory is obviously not as crude as Senator D'Amato's, but it too tends to be reductive about artistic quality.

Moralism says too little about how to identify the moral content of a work of art. To be fair, at times Dickie acknowledges that content is not just "there." His phrasing is revealingly vague: he says that many works "have an integral moral point of view" or present an "approving (or disapproving) representation" of some moral content. This elusive phrasing points to a

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major problem for the moralist: how we can tell what the moral content of an artwork work is? Was Serrano insulting Christians, as Senator D'Amato thought, or paying idiosyncratic homage to Christ, as Lippard thinks? Again, just what is the "integral moral point of view" of *The Satanic Verses*? The novel is more than five hundred pages long; it shifts through multiple characters, locales, and time frames; employs a complex narrative structure; exploits techniques of magical realism; and alludes to post-colonial politics and postmodern hybridities. The Muslims who took offense at it seemed to see the moral point in *The Satanic Verses* as a clear (and problematic) one, involving at the very least disrespect to the Prophet Mohammed and to his wives. Wendy Steiner comments that "Islamic critics were right to find not only its content but its form provocative."[34] But Rushdie's book is interpreted in a completely different way by Gayatri Spivak—who also offers a moral critique of it.[35] What shall we say of moral content in difficult cases like these? Moralist views of art do not tell us and do not seem to recognize the scope of the problem.

A second key problem is that moralists presume that we look at artworks after already having reached our moral views. Encountering the work itself apparently will have no important effect on our moral attitudes, since we are to move *from* our attitudes *to* assessments of the works' artistic merits.[36] This seems wrong. I want to argue that artworks can affect the moral views of their audiences. Isn't this exactly what censorious critics of artists like Rushdie, Serrano, and Mapplethorpe fear?—that viewers of their works will not simply be exposed to problematic moral views, but that they will come to sympathize with and adopt those views? Ironically, then, moralist critics may seek to censor art precisely because they recognize and distrust its power.

In sum, the limitations of moralism are these: (1) Like formalism, it too sharply separates the artistic and moral features of artworks, presuming that the moral features are independently identifiable; (2) It does not offer a good account of how moral content is present in artworks; and (3) It does not acknowledge the possibility that artists make intrinsic, creative contributions to our thoughts about moral issues.

COGNITIVISM

I have given very broad sketches of some formalist and moralist theories of art. For the formalist, artistic and moral values are autonomous; for the moralist, moral value is prior to and at least partially determines artistic value. I have criticized both views for failing to acknowledge the complex nature of moral content in artworks like those made famous by the recent controversies, and for failing to grasp the conceptual links between the "form" and

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"contents" of artworks. We will find a better approach in cognitivist views about art. Cognitivists do not hold that artistic and moral values are autonomous or that one type can trump or determine the other type; they are more likely to see these two types of value in artworks as fused or conceptually connected. Cognitivists locate a central value of artworks primarily in the thoughts or knowledge they communicate, or what we learn from them; and they take form or artistic quality to encompass and facilitate these cognitive dimensions of artworks. Or at least this is true of pragmatists and Aristotelians, who employ a broad conception of thoughts or knowledge rather than a narrow, discursive one. So they are neither moralists nor formalists about art; instead, they maintain the following claims: (1) Artworks may have moral content or present moral knowledge, as revealed by a process of rational interpretation; (2) Artistic features and moral content of works of art are conceptually linked; and (3) We can learn from the moral content of artworks.

Cognitivism as a general approach to art is hardly new. It was adopted in the ancient world by Plato and Aristotle, even though they disagreed about the moral merits of artworks like epic poetry and tragedy. I take the following list to encapsulate central theses in the cognitive view of art:

(1) Artworks stimulate cognitive activity that may teach us about the world. Some say artworks do this because they have representational (including expressive) content; others, because they function as symbols within a diversely structured system.
(2) The cognitive activity they stimulate is part and parcel of their functioning as artworks.
(3) As a result of this stimulation, we learn from artworks: we acquire fresh knowledge, our beliefs are refined, and our understanding is deepened.
(4) What we learn in this manner constitutes one of the main reasons we enjoy and value artworks in the first place.

Modern cognitivists like Nelson Goodman emphasize representational content in art, which may seem surprising given the development of modern art movements such as abstract painting and atonal music. However, for Goodman "content" is in fact quite broad; it turns out to be a matter of symbolic functioning and is inseparable from form. It encompasses such features of artworks as their style and expression, or even their emotional impact—all of these become part of what we "cognize" or understand about a work. So Goodman writes, "in aesthetic experience the emotions function cognitively. . . . To some extent, we may feel how a painting looks as we may see how it feels."[37] Features of art such as style or expression might formerly have been treated as "aesthetic properties," but in construing them as relevant to symbolic functioning, the modern cognitivist shifts attention onto

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how they function to represent a world and stimulate comprehension. For example, when Danto interprets the triptych *Jim and Tom, Sausalito* as Mapplethorpe's way of thinking about the transcendent and spiritual nature of sex, he discusses such factors as the triptych format, art-historical allusions, and the lighting in each frame. "Thinking" thus involves the photographer's style, composition, and expressive use of the medium, in addition to his depiction of a certain subject matter. I now take up more details from two modern variants on the cognitive view of art.

NUSSBAUM'S ARISTOTELIANISM

Martha Nussbaum offers a general account of moral knowledge and in this light makes claims about the kind of moral knowledge we can glean from art. She has developed her Aristotelian cognitive view of art in a number of key works.[38] On her view, some artworks—especially novels—have moral content; artistic features and moral content are conceptually connected in these works; and we can learn from the moral content of these artworks.

An Aristotelian like Nussbaum tends to give a kind of fused answer to the general questions with which I began: what is moral knowledge (in an artwork), and how can we learn from the moral content of artworks? To see how she answers both questions, we can look at her most extensive presentation of her view in the opening chapter of *Love's Knowledge.* Nussbaum adopts an Aristotelian conception of moral knowledge. She explains, "The essays argue for a conception of ethical understanding that involves emotional as well as intellectual activity and gives a certain type of priority to the perception of particular people and situations, rather than to abstract rules."[39] Here Nussbaum follows Aristotle's example in the *Nicomachean Ethics.* He emphasizes the role of emotions and desires in moral judgment, claiming that the rationality of ethics involves practical not theoretical wisdom. Practical wisdom is a unique rational capacity of humans that depends upon particularity of perception rather than upon universal rules; Aristotle repeatedly denies that ethics can be a science.

Nussbaum highlights features of the Aristotelian moral tradition that are shared by certain novels that she discusses in *Love's Knowledge.* These novels present an Aristotelian picture of moral knowledge by supporting four key positions. (1) First, these novels, like Aristotle, are committed to the noncommensurability of valuable things; this allows for deep conflicts between diverse competing attachments. (2) Second, they endorse the priority of perceptions. On this view, the perception of particulars of concrete actions, including awareness of context and of new or unanticipated features, is both more action-guiding and more relevant to justification than are

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general moral rules and principles. (3) They highlight the ethical value of the emotions: emotions are cognitive and have an important part to play in our practical reasoning and our moral agency. Finally, (4) these novels illustrate the ethical relevance of uncontrolled happenings. Things that simply happen, even reversals of fortune, have significance for how well we can lead our lives.[40] This last point, the recognition of contingency or moral luck, is something Nussbaum particularly admires in ancient philosophers and playwrights and calls this trait their openness to tragedy; it was the subject of her earlier book *The Fragility of Goodness.*

What about moral learning? First, Nussbaum says that we should add the study of certain novels (by Eliot, Proust, Dickens, and others) to the study of recognized great works in ethics, because these novels exemplify the Aristotelian procedure in ethical investigation that Nussbaum finds valuable.[41] So from these novels we can learn about moral inquiry: what it is, and how one pursues it. Even more, they present particular answers, which Nussbaum wants to defend, to the basic question of how to live. The appropriate procedure begins by asking "How should one live?" and continues on through a dialectical examination of the alternatives to advocate a certain answer. Nussbaum interprets Henry James' *The Golden Bowl,* for example, as a moral examination of the conflicting claims of a fine sense of moral rightness and of erotic attachment and the working out of the right balance between them.[42]

Second, literature has certain lessons to teach us as philosophers about how to do moral theory, because it reinforces what Nussbaum considers a basic point in ethics, that form should fit content.[43] That is, she thinks that systematic treatises in philosophy have certain ideals of regularization and simplicity that cannot capture some aspects of our moral lives and moral knowledge in the way that novels can. This is partly a matter of how we react to the respective kinds of writing—whether it *involves* us: "Our actual relation to the books we love is already messy, complex, erotic."[44] It is also because philosophy tends to oversimplify, whereas novels can better present "mysterious, various, and complex content"; Nussbaum emphasizes that "features that make the novels so unlike dogmatic treatises are, for us, the source of their philosophical interest."[45] She is attentive to the ways in which style enables an author to present a certain point of view. Literary readings may help us to read not only literature but also philosophy, because we can better discern the style and hence the related message of a philosopher. Nussbaum illustrates this point with brief readings of passages from Spinoza and Seneca, whose styles are obviously distinctive and relevant to their messages. Attention to style can also make a philosopher more attentive to his or her own style. Nussbaum mentions that she has found it essential to employ different philosophical styles in her various essays to respond to the literary works under consideration.[46]

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Third, in her more recent book *Poetic Justice* Nussbaum argues that literature offers something in addition to both method and content, namely, "literary imagination." This is a combination of empathy and detailed, compassionate presentation of characters. She remarks, "The literary imagination is a part of public rationality. . . . I defend the literary imagination precisely because it seems to me an essential ingredient of an ethical stance that asks us to concern ourselves with the good of other people whose lives are distant from our own."[47]

In defending her basic claims, Nussbaum has written extensively about a number of literary examples, especially ones drawn from what she herself calls "the high literary tradition of Europe and North America."[48] This includes the ancient tragedians, nineteenth-century realists (Dickens, George Eliot), and classical modernists (Henry James, Joyce, Proust, Beckett). In *Poetic Justice* her attention has turned to socially significant legal decisions in the United States, for example the notorious anti-homosexual ruling *Bowers vs. Hardwick.* She "reads" these decisions for their literary merits or defects, with the general assumption that the better decisions are those that better exemplify the literary imagination. So she faults the judges in *Bowers,* for example, for taking a detached, non-narrative approach that enabled what she criticizes as "a distancing strategy." This involved various factors, such as use of non-narrative language, severity of language, and enumeration of historical condemnations.[49] All this, together with lack of an appropriate level of generality in looking into the case, precluded what was needed, namely, "a careful attention to historical context, and an empathetic consideration of the situation of the homosexual in American society."[50] *Poetic Justice* makes strong claims about the need for law to become more literary, i.e., to incorporate the values of particularity and compassion or empathy which literary imagination would supply.

On Nussbaum's view, then, we learn from literature not propositions or truths, but rather "insights" or "a stance" or "moral capacities."[51] This fits with her Aristotelian view that cognition is fused with emotional perception, and that moral judgments require developed habits and abilities. Let us explore two critical issues about Nussbaum's Aristotelian kind of cognitivism about art. First, how does her view overcome the problem faced by both formalists and moralists about content—that is, how does she discern the moral content of the artworks she discusses? And, second, how much new moral knowledge can artists provide, on her view?

To discern their moral content, Nussbaum must offer interpretations of the works she reads. Sometimes she speaks about what literature "shows" us, suggesting the worry that her version of cognitivism does not differ enough from Dickie's moralism. Recall that I faulted Dickie for assuming that it is somehow simple just to *glean* the moral content of an artwork such

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as a tragedy. Nussbaum emphasizes that literature requires perceptive reading, and she produces lengthy interpretations of various works. Even so, at times she appears to think that the meaning of a work is fairly definite and fixed. Thus she writes, "I am interested, then, in all and only those thoughts, feelings, wishes, movements, and other processes that are actually there to be seen *in the text.*"[52] An example of her "unproblematizing" approach may be found in this passage about *The Golden Bowl:* "This novel, I have indicated, is about the development of a woman. To be a woman, to give herself to her husband, Maggie will need to come to see herself as something cracked, imperfect, unsafe, a vessel with a hole through which water may pass, a steamer compartment no longer tightly sealed."[53]

To be fair to Nussbaum, in *Love's Knowledge* she develops complex, elaborate readings of many works she discusses.[54] Unfortunately, such readings may well be contested. This happened in the case of her readings of tragedies, as reviewers of *The Fragility of Goodness* cited gaps or idiosyncrasies in her treatments.[55] But if others disagree with her interpretation of a work, then they will more than likely disagree with her account of the moral knowledge it offers. For instance, John Cooper argued that her interpretation of Euripides' *Hecuba* was mistaken: Hecuba is not, as Nussbaum thinks, a good woman driven mad by tragedy, but rather a woman revealed to be weak and flawed by her failure to face tragedy with strength. But this means Euripides did *not* in fact manifest the openness to tragedy that Nussbaum ascribes to him. This drives home the point that works of art have moral content and stimulate moral learning only under an interpretation.

In *Poetic Justice* Nussbaum acknowledges that readings of literature vary across individuals, eras, and cultures. She endorses Wayne Booth's approach to interpretation in his book *The Company We Keep: An Ethics of Fiction,* where he says we must not only read books but have critical conversations about them with others.[56] Along these lines, Nussbaum envisions a kind of public, rational discussion about the meaning of significant works. She presumably thinks that publishing her own interpretations of novels (as well as court cases) is in fact part of this public and critical conversation. Thus, rejoinders by other scholars might be welcome if they help us to describe, "really read," and assess the moral views of, say, Euripides or Sophocles, Dickens, or James. She sees reading itself in this sense as part of the creation of community along the lines required by Aristotelian moral inquiry.[57]

A second question to raise about Nussbaum's Aristotelian picture of moral knowledge is whether her moral commitments are "thick" or "thin." Is her theory again too much like Dickie's moralism, so that she knows in advance what is morally acceptable, or what is not, about a work? That is, an Aristotelian moral view carries with it certain "thick" moral commitments. Aristotle held a view about human nature, its needs and capabilities, and he

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used this to ground his account of human virtue and happiness *(eudaimonia).* To some degree at least, Nussbaum endorses this naturalism of Aristotle's and sees it as a way of blocking relativism.[58] To what extent, then, will her commitments be subject to revision in encounters with literature or other artworks that might provide genuinely new outlooks? In *Love's Knowledge* Nussbaum says she has chosen to discuss novels that exemplify a certain (i.e., Aristotelian) procedure and also certain (i.e., Aristotelian) answers to the question of how to define a good life. And in *Poetic Justice* she defends novels for their power to stimulate empathy and moral imagination. The good life involves a certain element of contingency that is dealt with through moral virtue. What would Nussbaum say about a novel like J. G. Ballard's *Crash,* which seems to overemphasize contingency and fate? In this book the narrator, after a car crash involving a fatality, becomes obsessed with and emulates a character named Vaughan, the "nightmare angel of the expressways" who has "spent his life staging death." Vaughan collects albums full of pictures of crash victims and can only find sexual excitement exploring the possibilities of scars and wounds. The narrator (also named Ballard) writes, "In our wounds we celebrated the re-birth of the traffic-slain dead, the deaths and injuries of those we had seen dying by the roadside and the imaginary wounds and postures of the millions yet to die."[59] Nussbaum's Aristotelian convictions might suggest that this book is unacceptable because it takes contingency too far and reconceptualizes human happiness in too bizarre a fashion. Even the imaginative enterprise of following through the characters' twisted desires and macabre sexual encounters—juxtaposing body parts with auto parts, semen, blood, and mucous with engine coolant—becomes repulsive. (For example, here is how the narrator describes his lover Gabrielle's body, which is covered by scars, grooves, and braces: "Each of her deformities became a potent metaphor for the excitement of a new violence. . . . Her body was a ripening anthology of perverse possibilities. . . . These were the templates for new genital organs, the moulds of sexual possibilities yet to be created in a hundred experimental car-crashes.")[60] Because she does have some prior moral commitments, Nussbaum seems to rule in and rule out certain novels for our moral learning; but this means that she seems to know in advance what can be learned from good literature, at least in outline, and which books to read. This does seem to sound like Dickie's strong moralism about art.

Nussbaum would probably respond by pointing out that there is a dialectic between our reading and our moral commitments. Anyone will read literature with some moral commitments; the Aristotelian emphasizes that people must come to the ethical enterprise with good training from childhood and from their society. The moral views we hold are subject to piecemeal reassessment on the basis of our continuing moral inquiries, where this

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might include our encounters with literature. Nussbaum wants to say that philosophy and literature interact in a rational dialogue. So, in *Poetic Justice* she makes two claims for the reader's experience:

> [F]irst, that it provides insights that should play a role (though not as uncriticized foundation) in the construction of an adequate moral and political theory; second, that it develops moral capacities without which citizens will not succeed in making reality out of the normative conclusions of any moral or political theory, however excellent . . . novel-reading will not give us the whole story about social justice, but it can be a bridge both to a vision of justice and to the social enactment of that vision.[61]

Notice the qualification that Nussbaum includes here when she says that moral insights gleaned from literature cannot be an *uncriticized* foundation for moral theory. Nussbaum remarks that her view has similarities with Rawls' notion of "reflective equilibrium" and suggests that there is a play between our rationally considered moral and political judgments and our reading. "Reading can lead us to alter some of our standing judgments, but it is also the case that these judgments can cause us to reject some experiences of reading as deforming or pernicious"; or, "an emphasis on the literary imagination is not meant to displace moral and political theory or to substitute emotions for principled arguments."[62] Presumably this is how she would deal with *Crash:* if we find ourselves, despite our better judgment, being drawn into the imaginative world of Ballard's characters, we must pause, reflect, and then reinstate that better judgment![63]

PUTNAM'S PRAGMATISM

I now take up an alternative kind of contemporary cognitive approach to art, pragmatism. Pragmatism also holds that art can present moral knowledge, that artistic quality and moral content are conceptually connected, and that we can learn from art's moral content. I shall focus on works by Hilary Putnam, a current pragmatist who addresses questions of ethics and values. We shall begin with the two broad opening questions I asked about Nussbaum's Aristotelianism: What is the pragmatist account of the nature of moral knowledge, and how does art provide such knowledge—that is, how and what can we learn from it?

Like the Aristotelian, the pragmatist holds that knowledge is not simply knowledge of propositions and truths. *What* we learn from art depends upon our aims, situations, and purposes. There can be knowledge *how* and emotional knowledge, for example. Art can convey knowledge of how to perceive the world around us, something not readily reducible to a series of

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propositions. Thus in *Art as Experience* Dewey notes that understanding art is like understanding another person.[64] Furthermore, art is integrally linked to a culture; Dewey claims that art expresses the life of the community. Moral life in general cannot be discussed outside the context of a culture and "cannot go on without the support of a moral environment"; such an environment "is created by the collective art of a time."[65]

In *Languages of Art* and later works, Nelson Goodman revised and extended this pragmatist view of art. Goodman's organicism and naturalism are not so readily apparent as Dewey's, yet I think they are present, especially when he makes comments like this: "What we know through art is felt in our bones and nerves and muscles as well as grasped by our minds. . . . [A]ll the sensitivity and responsiveness of the organism participates in the invention and interpretation of symbols."[66] Goodman describes artworks as complex structures of symbols that achieve meaning and reference in a variety of specific ways. They contribute to and enlarge upon our understanding of a world.[67] Goodman articulates criteria that make either scientific hypotheses or artworks successful: clarity, elegance, and a kind of fittingness: "Truth and its aesthetic counterpart amount to appropriateness under different names."[68] On the pragmatist view, scientific views and artworks create worlds that seem right in relation to our needs and habits (or what can become our habits). They help us, as Goodman puts it at the very conclusion of *Languages of Art,* "in the creation and comprehension of our worlds." I quote the following extended passage from Goodman because it offers a detailed account of how much the pragmatist counts as knowledge in art:

> Symbolization, then, is to be judged fundamentally by how well it serves the cognitive purpose: by the delicacy of its discriminations and the aptness of its allusions; by the way it works in grasping, exploring, and informing the world; by how it analyzes, sorts, orders, and organizes; by how it participates in the making, manipulation, retention, and transformation of knowledge. Considerations of simplicity and subtlety, power and precision, scope and selectivity, familiarity and freshness, are all relevant and often contend with one another; their weighting is relative to our interests, our information, and our inquiry.[69]

The effectiveness of symbol systems in art, as in science, is context-dependent. This explains why artworks, like scientific theories, change in both their appeal and their capacity to shock or fascinate over time: "A work may be successively offensive, fascinating, comfortable, and boring."[70] Goodman entertains the possibility that art affords moral knowledge in his discussion of the related notion of "rightness of rendering" in *Ways of Worldmaking.* This notion goes beyond truth to include "standards of acceptability that sometimes supplement or even compete with truth . . . or replace truth for nondeclarative renderings."[71] While Goodman acknowledges that

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"any treatment of rightness may, of course, give rise to speculation concerning an application to moral rightness" he avoids this context, commenting that "I willingly leave that to others."[72]

Among the few "others" who have risen to this challenge is Hilary Putnam. In fact, Putnam criticizes Goodman and Quine for neglecting ethics in their pragmatist programs. He says that they "have been somewhat hesitant to forthrightly extend the same approach [viz., their pragmatism] to our moral images of ourselves and the world. Yet what can giving up the spectator view in philosophy mean if we don't extend the same approach to the most indispensible 'versions' of ourselves and the world that we possess? Like William James . . . I propose to do exactly that."[73] Putnam has articulated a pragmatist conception of moral knowledge, together with some claims about how this knowledge may be found in works of art, especially literature. Let us first consider his view of moral knowledge.

Putnam says that he agrees with earlier pragmatist critiques of moral a priorism.[74] Yet he does not endorse moral skepticism or cultural relativism, and he does maintain that there is moral knowledge. Though there are no moral "facts," some ethical principles are likely to have a "large measure of objectivity."[75] He sketches a pragmatist argument "that the belief in the cognitive status of value judgments underlies an enormous amount of our practice."[76] Putnam's pragmatism thus leads him to reject narrow instrumentalist notions of rationality that compare ethics unfavorably to other, allegedly more legitimate (or "more rational") forms of knowledge, like science. He holds that justification in ethics is also—equally—a rational enterprise, one that involves recognizing that "*all* values, including the cognitive ones, get their authority from our idea of human flourishing and our idea of reason. These two ideas are interconnected: our image of an ideal theoretical intelligence is simply a *part* of our ideal of total human flourishing. . . ."[77] Putnam explicitly invokes Dewey's conception of inquiry as his own paradigm for the search for knowledge, noting that Dewey rejected the model of an algorithm: "According to the pragmatists, whether the subject be science or ethics, what we have are maxims and not algorithms; and maxims themselves require contextual interpretation."[78]

Given this view of moral knowledge, what does Putnam say about the moral content of art, or about what we can learn from artworks? In some earlier essays he assumed a less pragmatic, more narrowly discursive view of knowledge, and contrasted what we can derive from literature with the sort of knowledge required for ethics. In "Literature, Science, and Reflection," published in 1976, Putnam argued that literature differs from philosophy as a source of moral knowledge. Literary works offer only what he calls conceptual knowledge, "an imaginative re-creation of moral perplexities." "You don't learn that certain things are true from a novelist, but what the world

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looks like to someone who thinks that."[79] Thus perhaps one learns from *Medea* about how jealousy and wrath could lead a woman to harm her children, or from *The Brothers Karamazov* why a son would kill a father from jealous passion. Such conceptual knowledge, says Putnam, may amount to a new interpretation of the facts. He says it should be more than knowledge of mere possibilities; a novelist like Celine who writes only about the "merely" possible is weak.

Conceptual knowledge, in this essay, is contrasted with genuine moral knowledge, which Putnam says is "propositional" and "factual" knowledge of standards and principles. Conceptual knowledge is inferior because it has not been tested. Thus presumably the conceptual knowledge of what it might feel like to be a Medea capable of killing her children does not offer us genuine moral knowledge about whether, in any circumstances, infanticide is justifiable or morally right. Though what we derive from literature is not factual knowledge, the conceptual knowledge it affords *is* worthwhile. So Putnam writes, "Objectivity of ethical principles is connected with such things as width of appeal, ability to withstand rational criticism, feasibility, ideality, and what it feels like to live by them or attempt to live by them. Imagination and sensibility are essential instruments of practical reasoning. The literary imagination does really help us to understand ourselves and life (reasoning about how to live)."[80] Novelists who use the medium appropriately give us something that we need in order to gain moral knowledge.

Putnam returned to this topic in his 1983 response to Nussbaum, "Taking Rules Seriously." In most of this essay he still presents a somewhat narrow view of how much knowledge literature can offer, emphasizing the difference between knowledge from literature and real moral knowledge. He suggests that when we do gain moral knowledge from a novel, it is because of a philosophical discussion or description of the book, rather than from the work itself. Thus he notes with approval Richard Wollheim's thought that it is the commentary on a literary work, not the work itself, which may be a work of moral philosophy.[81]

Still, Putnam acknowledges that imagination and sensibility are essential instruments of moral reasoning and that literature may be useful because it demonstrates that moral reasoning takes place in a context.[82] However, he begins to note problems in drawing the distinction between literature and philosophy when he confesses that "I suspect that both the ontological pretensions and the epistemological pretensions of philosophy have failed."[83] And in a few concluding sentences of the essay he uses scare quotes to indicate his doubts about certain purported distinctions between fictional works and moral philosophy, acknowledging the possibility that perhaps moral works in philosophy are themselves not "foundations" or "methodologies" but are themselves like works of literature:

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> A great philosophical picture, one might argue, should be viewed as we view great artistic creations: as something which does not simply copy a ready-made world, but rather as something which creates a world—or even, as Nelson Goodman has put it, a "world of worlds." . . . If such a view of philosophy can be elaborated and defended, then it may be that we have to view all philosophy as having an expressive component: as being concerned to reveal (or conceal) an author as much as to "solve problems." The gap between works of fiction and works of philosophy might then appear considerably narrower. (The commentary on a work of fiction can require a commentary, too.)[84]

Putnam has taken further steps toward breaking down distinctions between ethics and literature—mainly from the side of ethics or moral theory—by developing his key notion of "moral images." Thus in the 1987 Carus Lecture, "Equality and Our Moral Image of the World," he says that even great moral philosophers like Kant were really doing "philosophical anthropology," and that Kant's ethics offered us a moral image—"a vision which includes and organizes a complex system of values."[85] We have many moral images available to us: Jerusalem (Judaism) and the French Revolution offer similar moral images based on "equality," while the Roman and "liberal left" tradition emphasize civic republicanism. Again walking a fine line between realism and relativism, Putnam writes that "[m]oral image are human creations, but they can be right or wrong."[86] This rightness or wrongness is a matter of rational discussion within contexts and communities. To promote such rational discussion, Putnam thinks that we require complementary moral images of the world. (Here he differs from Kant, who was too "monistic" about his moral image.) We need both more—and more varied—moral images.[87]

Putnam now seems to be advocating a view of philosophy as itself a kind of art, the creative production of a vision useful for human purposes. At this point it would seem that literature is potentially of equal value, since it too offers moral images, and what we need is a plurality of such images. To pursue this possibility, let me now raise the two questions for Putnam that I raised earlier for Nussbaum. How do we discern the moral content of artworks like novels—is it like discerning the moral image in a philosopher's text? And just how "thick" are the moral commitments of his sort of pragmatism?

Putnam discusses the issue of interpretation in his essay "Is There a Fact of the Matter about Fiction?"[88] He reverts to considering a topic mentioned in "Taking Rules Seriously": is the moral theory of a novel supplied by a commentary on it? He now moves toward noting parallels between interpretation in philosophy and in literature: "There is, to be sure, a difference in this regard between a philosophical text and a literary one; but not a total difference."[89] Putnam asks how an interpretation of a work, or an exegesis

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of what it *says,* relates to a commentary about it, or a discussion of what it *implies*; and he argues that there is no real distinction between the two: "in a significant sense, the exegesis/commentary distinction cannot be drawn. Any exegesis that is nontrivial must, to that extent, be commentary-laden."[90] What, then, is a commentary? In short, it is an account of implications of what someone—whether Aristotle or Henry James—wrote "about our problems." Thus "getting at" the moral content of a work and presenting it in some discursive format or commentary actually turns out to be the same as interpreting the work, in the sense of construing how it says what it says. Philosophy and literature are on a par, then, because each kind of writing needs interpretation-cum-commentary so that we can see how its moral images speak to us in our current situations of intellectual and moral perplexity. Interpretation, like other forms of intellectual inquiry, is context-dependent and varies according to people's positions, assumptions, and surrounding institutions.[91]

And what can we say about Putnam's moral commitments? His pragmatism at first appears to be remarkably similar to Nussbaum's Aristotelianism in that, like her, he holds that rational debate is relevant and possible in ethics, and he thinks that rational debate is grounded in the rationality of the *community.* Putnam alludes less to Aristotle's views on moral justification, though, than to the picture of rationality developed by Peirce and followed up on by the Frankfurt School.[92] Eventually we reach not Aristotle's grounding in human needs and capacities, nor a rational foundation like the Moral Law, but rather the "bedrock" of our commitments to which Wittgenstein referred when he said that, ultimately, for either ethics or epistemology, we must insist simply, "This is where my spade is turned." So Putnam rejects a strict foundationalism as sought by both capital "E" Epistemology and capital "M" Metaphysics, but he still insists that this is not "Feyerabendian relativism"; rational criticism of a moral vision is possible.[93]

Given that Putnam says that what we need are more and more varied moral images, and that we still need better accounts in philosophy of the nature of moral reasoning, then it would seem that in our commentaries we need to reason about all the moral images we can consider, both those of philosophers and those of novelists. In suggesting that philosophical systems of morality are not different in kind from literature, in that both offer us human creations, or moral images, Putnam has, in effect, dropped his earlier distinction between conceptual and factual knowledge about morality. He has, in fact, moved closer to a position like Dewey's—we should recall that Dewey claimed that art actually has more moral power than the "reflective treatises" of philosophers.[94]

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CONCLUSION

The pragmatist and the Aristotelian both argue that art may function to inform and illuminate the world and our lives—including our moral lives. It is a central strength of cognitivism that it regards moral content and artistic functioning of a work as more integrally connected than they are on either of the simple views I described at the start, namely, formalism or moralism. So an artwork may both challenge and stimulate us; it can engage the viewer simultaneously with both artistic interpretation and moral reflection.

There are, of course, other kinds of cognitive theories of art besides those I have described here. Recent years have seen a proliferation of cognitive studies of various art forms, including music, film, visual arts, and literature. Many of these views employ broad notions of knowledge. They emphasize ways in which the experience of art both utilizes and enhances our various cognitive skills, including not just imagination but perception of our changing environment, of sound or spatial relationships, and so on

Since both the pragmatist and the Aristotelian use very broad conceptions of knowledge, their views of art will be rejected by someone who maintains that moral knowledge must take a specific and narrower discursive form, as propositions or truths.[95] Someone with this sort of narrow view of the nature of moral knowledge will be likely to maintain that at best art affords examples or illustrations, that it cannot be a source of such knowledge.

Nussbaum and Putnam acknowledge the important role of interpretation (or what Putnam calls "commentaries"); these are required in order to provide accounts of the ways artworks serve as a source of moral knowledge. Often the confusion and lack of dialogue in the recent cases show that to understand an artwork's moral content requires fairly complex acts of artistic interpretation. Islamic fundamentalists don't *understand* the vocabulary of magical realism; Mapplethorpe's critics don't *understand* his gay urban S&M aesthetic; and Serrano's critics don't *understand* that *Piss Christ* could mean something other than "Piss *on* Christ." For Nussbaum and Putnam, the content/value distinction is more complex than it is according to the formalist or moralist. Cognitive views better reflect and explain these recent debates about art.

As a final comment, it is worth noting that both Nussbaum's and Putnam's accounts of art and moral knowledge focus mainly on literature. We can ask whether their views can be generalized to other arts. Nussbaum does think that novels are special, and she notes salient features of the novel: it is still a living form, and it offers us great narrative detail, emotional expressiveness, a concrete depiction of different ways of life, and an interest in the ordinary. She acknowledges that other art forms, like film. may offer similar features that make them moral resources.[96] I believe that her account of

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the moral content of art can be generalized to other art forms—other forms also do the key things that she attributes to the novel: they consider philosophical questions and provide methods of pursuing them as well as actual answers. To see how they do this we would need to look in more detail at interpretations like those I mentioned at the start, at what, for example, Levinson says about Ice-T's denunciation of commercial values in his rap song, or at Lippard's claims about Serrano's idiosyncratic homage to Christianity.

Can songs or photographs also supply something akin to Nussbaum's "literary imagination"? I think we can say yes if we look at, say, Danto's discussion of Mapplethorpe's images. Danto reads these images as the representation and expression of the photographer's empathetic relationship with subjects who trusted him to portray a lifestyle they shared, and one that some people considered worth exploring. Danto thinks that the success of the images lies in making this point of view available to someone like himself who finds what is pictured "fairly repellent," but who can still recognize a continuum of sexual imagination between what is pictured and more mainstream trappings of sexual fantasy like, say, black lingerie.[97] And perhaps we could say that photographs like *Piss Christ* or rap songs like "Pusher" also supply moral images, to use Putnam's terms. Putnam emphasizes the need for interpretations or exegeses, and there does not seem to be any good reason to suppose that exegeses could not reveal the moral images offered by such artworks.

I suspect that the real reason for philosophers to focus on literature can be found in Nussbaum's remarks about how sensitivity to literature can also illuminate the style or form of philosophy. Novels, like philosophical texts, are made of words. Nussbaum can thus read Spinoza or Seneca or Lucretius for their literary qualities; but how do we find the elements of a philosopher that are painterly, filmic, photographic, or musical? Maybe this is a limitation of philosophers, though (or of our view of what counts as philosophy)—and not a limitation of cognitive theories of art.

NOTES

1. Various versions of this paper have been read at the University of Pennsylvania, the Australian National University, the University of Sydney, Rice University, and the University of Wales, Aberystwyth (at the "Literature and Ethics" conference). I thank many people at these venues for helpful questions and comments (especially the participants in my seminars at the ANU, including Paul Thom, Jennifer McMahon, Natalie Stoljar, Ian Gold, and Michael Smith). David Hills offered generous (and detailed) helpful comments on several drafts. I am also grateful for support received from the University of Houston and the Australian National University.

2. On Aeschylus, see Thomas Gould, *The Ancient Quarrel Between Poetry and Philosophy* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1990), 122–23; on Michelangelo, see Leo

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Steinberg, *The Sexuality of Christ in Renaissance Art and in Modern Oblivion,* 2d ed., rev. and expanded (Chicago and London: University of Chicago Press, 1996), 19–21 and 146–47.

3. Lucy Lippard, "The Spirit and The Letter," *Art in America* (Apr. 1990): 244. This essay is reprinted and excerpted in *Culture Wars: Documents from the Recent Controversies in the Arts,* ed. Richard Bolton (New York: New Press, 1992), 201–05.
4. Lippard, in *Culture Wars,* 201.
5. Arthur Danto, *Playing with the Edge: The Photographic Achievement of Robert Mapplethorpe* (Berkeley and Los Angeles: University of California Press, 1996), 91; see also 83–95. "What he [Mapplethorpe] did, almost inconceivably, was confer a certain radiance on the act and even the tawdry place where it happens" (90).
6. Jerrold Levinson, "Messages in Art," in *Art and Its Messages: Meaning, Morality, and Society,* ed. Stephen Davies (University Park, Pa.: Pennsylvania State University Press, 1997), 78–81.
7. Wendy Steiner, *The Scandal of Pleasure: Art in an Age of Fundamentalism* (Chicago and London: University of Chicago Press, 1995), 105.
8. Jerome Stolnitz, "On the Cognitive Triviality of Art," *British Journal of Aesthetics* 32 (1992): 191–200. For a discussion and critique of this view, see T. J. Diffey, "What Can We Learn from Art?" in *Art and Its Messages,* 26–33.
9. Stolnitz, "On the Cognitive Triviality of Art," 194, 200.
10. Levinson, "Messages in Art," 78. I should point out that Levinson adds various qualifiers to this interpretation and is not hasty to assert its truth!
11. Charles Sanders Peirce, "How to Make Our Ideas Clear," in *Pragmatism: A Contemporary Reader,* ed. Russell Goodman (New York and London: Routledge, 1995), 41.
12. Ibid., 43. See also William James in "Pragmatism's Conception of Truth": "Any idea that helps us to deal, whether practically or intellectually, with either the reality or its belongings, that doesn't entangle our progress in frustrations, that fits, in fact, and adapts our life to the reality's whole setting, will agree sufficiently to meet the requirement" (*Pragmatism: The Classic Writings,* ed. H. S. Thayer [Indianapolis and Cambridge: Hackett, 1982], 234).
13. I think this is so, even though I am in agreement with scholars like Myles Burnyeat and Bas Van Fraassen who have discussed the role of "understanding" in Aristotle and highlighted pragmatic elements of Aristotle's philosophy of science. For an overview, see my "Scientific Explanation and Empirical Data in Aristotle's *Meteorology,*" in *Oxford Studies in Ancient Philosophy* 7 (1990): 67–102; and "Accidental Causes and Real Explanations," in *Essays on Aristotle's Physics,* ed. Lindsay Judson (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1991), 49–72.
14. For examples and further discussion, see chap. 9, "Art and Morals," in Melvin Rader and Bertram Jessup, *Art and Human Values* (Englewood Cliffs, N.J.: Prentice-Hall, 1976), 212–34. Rader and Jessup label the distinction I have in mind "aestheticism" versus "moralism," and while they do not describe these views exactly as I do here, most examples they list under each category would fit my descriptions as well.
15. I here discount "aesthetic idea" types of formalists like Suzanne Langer or R. G. Collingwood; they really count more as cognitivists, the way I read them, since the "form" of art presents ideas. (Jennifer McMahon drew this point to my attention.)
16. For Kant, the beautiful object carries no particular cognitive content, but rather its form stimulates "free play of imagination," a kind of harmonious interplay between understanding and sensibility that is a disinterested and universally communicable state of mind. It is a sensible analog of the rationally grounded impersonality characteristic of moral judgment. This is why Kant calls beauty a symbol of morality. See Ted Cohen, "Why Beauty Is a Symbol of Morality," in *Essays in Kant's Aesthetics,* ed. Ted Cohen and Paul Guyer (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1982), 221–36.
17. For an overview, see Deane W. Curtin, "Varieties of Aesthetic Formalism," *Journal of Aesthetics and Art Criticism* 40 (1982): 315–26.

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18. William Gass, "The Baby or the Botticelli," in his *Finding a Form* (New York: Alfred A. Knopf, 1996), 287.
19. Kramer, "Is Art Above the Laws of Decency?" *New York Times,* July 2, 1989; reprinted in *Culture Wars,* 54.
20. Ibid., 55.
21. Danto responds to this point; for a summary, see Danto, *Playing with the Edge,* 17–18. Even those who are suspicious about the aesthetic, such as Plato, recognize its value, for they hold that the "very excellence of a work of bad moral content or suggestion may render it doubly unacceptable" (Rader and Jessup, *Art and Human Values,* 213). Rader and Jessup cite Plato and the Shanghai Communist paper as exemplifying this view.
22. See Elizabeth Hess, "Art on Trial: Cincinnati's Dangerous Theater of the Ridiculous," *Village Voice,* Oct. 23, 1990; reprinted in *Culture Wars,* 277.
23. Danto, *Playing with the Edge,* 88–89.
24. Clive Bell, "The Aesthetic Hypothesis," in *Philosophy of Art and Aesthetics from Plato to Wittgenstein,* ed. Frank A. Tillman and Steven M. Cahn (New York: Harper & Row, 1969), 415–28.
25. Some would say that her earlier film *Day of Freedom: Our Fighting Forces* glorifies the German military machine. For a complex assessment, see the documentary by Ray Muller, *The Wonderful, Horrible Life of Leni Riefenstahl* (1993).
26. Some of Mapplethorpe's own statements sound disingenuous on this point. He supposedly remarked, for example, "I don't think there's that much difference between a photograph of a fist up someone's ass and a photograph of carnations in a bowl" (quoted in Steven C. Dubin, *Arresting Images: Impolitic Art and Uncivil Actions* [New York: Routledge, 1992], 172). Of course, Mapplethorpe's flower images are themselves notoriously sexualized; on this, Danto remarks that their beauty "is a compound of elegance and menace"; see *Playing with the Edge,* 119.
27. Of course, it is open for the moralist to say that art may have a neutral content. If, for example, an Audubon print has no particularly good or bad moral content, but is simply a lovely depiction of a swan, it might make a nice gift and hence be used to contribute to a moral act of generosity.
28. Thus I am not using this label here to describe someone like Kramer, who thinks that objectionable moral content can provide the basis for condemning even good art.
29. Sen. Alfonse D'Amato, Debate in the U.S. Senate, May 18, 1989, quoted in *Culture Wars,* 28.
30. Dickie, *Evaluating Art,* 126–27.
31. Ibid., 127.
32. Ibid., 159.
33. Ibid., 136, emphasis mine.
34. Steiner, *The Scandal of Pleasure,* 107.
35. See Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak, "Reading *The Satanic Verses,*" in Spivak, *Outside in the Teaching Machine* (New York and London: Routledge, 1993), 217–41.
36. Even in cases where the moral issues might be somewhat murky, I suspect that the moral position an artist works out in his or her work will be endorsed or "approved" by the moralist only on independent grounds.
37. Nelson Goodman, *Languages of Art,* 2d ed. (Indianapolis: Hackett, 1976), 248.
38. These works include *The Fragility of Goodness: Luck and Ethics in Greek Tragedy and Philosophy* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1986), hereafter referred to as FG; *Love's Knowledge: Essays on Philosophy and Literature* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1990), hereafter referred to as LK; and *Poetic Justice: The Literary Imagination and Public Life* (Boston: Beacon Press, 1995), hereafter referred to as PJ.
39. LK, ix.
40. Ibid., 36ff.

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41. Ibid., 27. See also Nussbaum's comment, in PJ, 29, on deconstruction's recent concern with ethics.
42. LK, 53.
43. Ibid., 3.
44. Ibid., 29.
45. Ibid.
46. She emphasizes the need for a nonreductive, imaginative commentary that directs readers to a work's variety and complexity; see ibid., 49.
47. Preface to PJ, xvi.
48. LK, 45n. 8.
49. PJ, 111–14.
50. PJ, 115.
51. Hence, I think Jenefer Robinson is wrong to accuse Nussbaum of treating emotions as beliefs and saying that Nussbaum thinks "learning through fiction would then seem to consist in the acquisition of beliefs." See Jenefer Robinson, "L'Education Sentimentale," in *Art and Its Messages,* 34–48.
52. LK, 9, emphasis mine.
53. LK, 133–34.
54. Similarly, Nussbaum acknowledges in FG that "[i]interpreting tragedy is a messier, less determinate, more mysterious matter than assessing a philosophical example" (14); but still, her interpretations have been seen by critics as rather arbitrary and subject to challenge. See next note.
55. T. H. Irwin, *Journal of Philosophy* (1988): 376–83; John Cooper, *Philosophical Review* 97 (1988): 543–64; A. A. Long, *Classical Philology* 83 (1988): 361–69. These critics mentioned numerous other points, too. Cooper claimed that philosophers argue and give reasons for moral views, but that no tragedy does this (562–63); Irwin noted that some of the reasons Nussbaum gives for turning to literature for moral insight would apply at least equally well to other sources, such as history and biography (381n. 8).
56. PJ, 9.
57. See LK, 48.
58. For more details and qualifications, see her essay "Non-Relative Virtues: An Aristotelian Approach," in *The Quality of Life,* ed. Martha C. Nussbaum and Amartya Sen (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1993), 242–69. There she writes, "The Aristotelian virtues, and the deliberation they guide, . . . remain always open to revision in the light of new circumstances and new evidence" (259–60).
59. J. G. Ballard, *Crash* (New York: Noonday Press, 1973; reprint, 1996), 203. The book has been recently made into a film by David Cronenberg, also the subject of controversy. Of course, some might see the deadpan style of the book as ironic, itself an implied critique of the amorality and anomie it depicts. I would argue against this kind of interpretation, though I cannot do so in the space here.
60. The worst passage, to my mind, is when the narrator visualizes fantasies of "contented pedophiliacs, hiring the deformed bodies of children injured in crashes, assuaging and irrigating their wounds with their own scarred genital organs, of elderly pederasts easing their tongues into the simulated anuses of colostomized juveniles" (Ballard, *Crash,* 180). This level of vivid, disgusting description makes Mapplethorpe's worst images look like good clean fun.
61. PJ, 12.
62. PJ, 10, 12.
63. Alan H. Goldman criticizes Nussbaum for aestheticizing morality. This charge strikes me as wrongheaded because it misses the Aristotelianism in her view of morality. See Goldman, *Aesthetic Value* (Boulder, Colo.: Westview Press, 1995), 143–49.

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64. Dewey, *Art as Experience* (New York: G. P. Putnam's Sons, 1934), 336.
65. Ibid., 345.
66. Goodman, *Languages of Art,* 259. I am indebted to the account of Dewey's theory of art given by Richard Shusterman in *Pragmatist Aesthetics: Living Beauty, Rethinking Art* (Oxford: Blackwell, 1992), 3–33.
67. Goodman, *Languages of Art*; *Ways of Worldmaking* (Indianapolis: Hackett, 1978).
68. Goodman, *Languages of Art,* 264; see also 255–65.
69. Ibid., 258.
70. Ibid., 259.
71. Goodman, *Ways of Worldmaking,* 110.
72. Ibid., 109–10n. 1.
73. Hilary Putnam, *The Many Faces of Realism: The Paul Carus Lectures* (La Salle, Ill.: Open Court, 1987), 21; hereafter this work is referred to as MF.
74. "Pragmatism and Moral Objectivity," in *Words and Life,* ed. James Conant (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 1994), 151.
75. See Putnam, MF, 77–78, and "Literature, Science, and Reflection," in *Meaning and the Moral Sciences* (Boston and London: Routledge & Kegan Paul, 1978), 93.
76. Putnam, "Pragmatism and Moral Objectivity," 160.
77. Putnam, "Beyond the Fact/Value Dichotomy," in *Realism with a Human Face,* ed. James Conant (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 1990), 141; Putnam's emphasis; hereafter referred to as RwHF.
78. Putnam, "Pragmatism and Moral Objectivity," 172.
79. Putnam, "Literature, Science, and Reflection," 89.
80. Ibid., 91.
81. Putnam, "Taking Rules Seriously," in *RwHF,* 200.
82. Ibid., 193–200.
83. Ibid., 200.
84. Ibid.
85. Putnam, MF, 51. In "Taking Rules Seriously," he does not use the term "moral images" but does refer to "normative pictures" presented by Aristotle and Kant; see esp. 197.
86. Putnam, MF, 78.
87. Mark Johnson also defends the view that morality—even a putatively "pure" rationalistic ethics like Kant's—is chiefly a matter of metaphor and moral imagination in his book, *Moral Imagination: Implications of Cognitive Science for Ethics* (Chicago and London: University of Chicago Press, 1993); on Kant see esp. 65–77.
88. Putnam, "Is There a Fact of the Matter about Fiction?" in *RwHF,* 209–13.
89. Ibid., 212.
90. Ibid., 213.
91. Ibid., 210.
92. Putnam, MF, 81–83. Though Putnam agrees with Apel and Habermas that claims aiming at truth and warrant must recognize implicitly the authority of an ongoing community which must have a certain structure, he thinks that this project is still too Kantian, too much an attempt to construct a universal ethic; see MF, 53–56.
93. Ibid., 86.
94. John Dewey, *Art as Experience,* 345.
95. Stolnitz, "On the Cognitive Triviality of Art."
96. This issue of whether her view might apply to other artistic media is something Nussbaum briefly acknowledges in her "Endnote" to the Beckett essay in LK, 312–13.
97. Danto, *Playing with the Edge,* 93–95.

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